

OpenClaw Troubleshooting Guide

The complete fix-it guide for local installations (Mac, Linux, Windows)

This guide covers every common problem you might run into while running OpenClaw locally on your own computer. For each issue, you'll find the symptoms to look for, what causes it, and the exact steps to fix it. Every command is explained in plain English so you don't need any technical background to follow along.

All commands in this guide are designed to be run in your computer's terminal. On Mac, open Terminal (search for it in Spotlight). On Windows, open PowerShell or Command Prompt. On Linux, open your terminal application.

Quick reference — the two commands that fix most problems:

```
openclaw doctor --fix
```

What this does: Runs OpenClaw's built-in health checker and automatically fixes common issues like permissions, missing files, and config errors.

```
openclaw gateway restart
```

What this does: Restarts the OpenClaw gateway so it picks up any changes.

If those two commands don't solve your problem, find your specific issue below.

What's In This Guide

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- Problem 2: Agent shows 'typing' but never replies
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Problem 1

Gateway Won't Start

This is the most common problem on local installations. You type `openclaw gateway` and it either crashes immediately or shows an error about a port being in use.

Symptoms:

- You see 'EADDRINUSE: address already in use 127.0.0.1:18789'
- Gateway starts but immediately shows 'CIAO PROBING CANCELLED' and exits
- You see 'Gateway already running locally. Stop it first.'
- You see 'Config invalid' and the gateway refuses to start

Fix 1 — Force start (kills any stuck process):

```
openclaw gateway --force
```

What this does: Kills any old OpenClaw process that's stuck on the port and starts a fresh gateway. This fixes the problem most of the time.

Fix 2 — Stop the existing gateway first:

```
openclaw gateway stop
```

Then start it again:

```
openclaw gateway
```

Fix 3 — Config is invalid:

If the error mentions 'Config invalid', your configuration file has a bad value. Run the doctor to fix it:

```
openclaw doctor --fix
```

Then try starting the gateway again. If the doctor can't fix it automatically, you can see the config file yourself:

Mac / Linux: open `~/openclaw/openclaw.json` in any text editor

Windows: open `%USERPROFILE%\openclaw\openclaw.json` in Notepad

Look for the value the error message mentions (like `groupPolicy` or `dmPolicy`) and check that it's set to a valid option. Common valid values: `groupPolicy` should be "open", "disabled", or "allowlist". `dmPolicy` should be "pairing", "allowlist", "open", or "disabled".

Fix 4 — Use a different port:

```
openclaw gateway --port 18790
```

What this does: Starts the gateway on a different port. Useful if something else on your computer is using port 18789.

Problem 2

Agent Shows 'Typing' But Never Replies

Symptoms:

- You see 'typing...' in Telegram but the message never arrives
- Agent seems to be thinking but eventually gives up silently

What happened: The AI model your agent is using isn't responding. This usually happens when the model's API is slow, down, or the session is stuck.

Fix 1 — Start a new session:

Type `/new` in Telegram. This clears the current session and starts fresh. Then type "hello" to test.

Fix 2 — Switch to a different model:

Type `/model` in Telegram, then browse providers and pick a different model (like Claude Sonnet or Haiku). If `/model` doesn't respond either, try Fix 3.

Fix 3 — Restart the gateway:

Go to the terminal window where OpenClaw is running, press Ctrl+C to stop it, then start it again:

```
openclaw gateway
```

Wait a minute, then type `/new` in Telegram followed by "hello".

Problem 3

Agent Not Responding At All

Symptoms:

- No 'typing' indicator, no response, complete silence
- Agent was working before but suddenly stopped

What happened: The gateway process probably stopped or crashed. This can happen if your computer went to sleep, the terminal window was closed, or the process crashed.

Fix 1 — Check if the gateway is running:

Look at the terminal window where you started OpenClaw. If you see a normal command prompt instead of scrolling logs, the gateway has stopped. Start it again:

```
openclaw gateway
```

Fix 2 — Force start if it won't start normally:

```
openclaw gateway --force
```

Fix 3 — Run the doctor:

```
openclaw doctor --fix
```

Then start the gateway again. This catches and fixes config errors, missing files, and permission problems.

Fix 4 — Check the logs for clues:

OpenClaw saves logs to a file. On Mac and Linux, check:

```
ls /tmp/openclaw/
```

Open the most recent log file and look for error messages. Common ones: Config invalid (see Problem 1), ECONNREFUSED (gateway didn't start), EADDRINUSE (port conflict).

Important: If your computer goes to sleep, the gateway stops. When you wake your computer up, you'll need to restart the gateway. This is one of the main differences between running locally and running on a VPS — a VPS never sleeps.

Problem 4

API Credits Ran Out or Rate Limit Hit

Symptoms:

- Agent stops responding or gives blank/empty messages
- Agent was working fine earlier today but suddenly stopped
- No error messages — just silence

What happened: Your API credits ran out or you hit the rate limit (too many requests too quickly). OpenClaw doesn't show an error message when this happens — the agent just goes quiet.

Fix — Check your credit balance:

- Anthropic: Go to console.anthropic.com → check your credit balance and rate limit tier
- OpenAI: Go to platform.openai.com → check your usage and billing
- OpenRouter: Go to openrouter.ai/credits → check your balance
- Google Gemini: Go to aistudio.google.com → check your quota

If credits are low, add more. If you hit a rate limit, wait a few minutes and try again. You can also switch to a free model as a temporary fix: type `/model` in Telegram and switch to a free option like MiniMax M2.5 via OpenRouter.

Tip: This is the most common reason for an agent going silent, and it's the easiest to miss because there's no error message. Always check your credit balance first before troubleshooting anything else.

Problem 5

Agent Not Responding in Telegram Groups

Symptoms:

- Agent works in DMs but ignores messages in groups
- You tag the agent but it doesn't respond

What happened: The agent's group policy is set to "allowlist" (default) which means it only responds in groups that are explicitly approved. Or the agent doesn't have admin permissions in the group.

Fix 1 — Make sure the bot is an admin:

Open the group → group info → Edit → Administrators → Add Admin → select your bot → Done.

Fix 2 — Enable group support:

In your DM with the agent, type: I want to use Telegram groups. Set `groupPolicy` to "open" and keep `requireMention` true. Apply the change and restart the gateway.

Warning: Make sure the agent sets `groupPolicy` to "open" — NOT "denylist". The value "denylist" is not valid and will crash OpenClaw. If the agent suggests "denylist", tell it to use "open" instead. See Problem 1 if this has already happened.

Fix 3 — Fix it manually if the agent already crashed:

Open your config file in a text editor:

Mac / Linux: `~/.openclaw/openclaw.json`

Windows: `%USERPROFILE%\openclaw\openclaw.json`

Find "groupPolicy" and change its value to "open". Save the file. Then restart the gateway.

Problem 6

Agent Stuck After Restart

Symptoms:

- You ran `/restart` and the agent never came back
- Agent shows as online but doesn't respond to anything

Fix 1 — Start a new session:

Type `/new` in Telegram. This is the most common fix — the old session got stuck during the restart.

Fix 2 — Restart the gateway:

Go to the terminal where OpenClaw is running, press `Ctrl+C`, then:

```
openclaw gateway
```

Wait a minute, then type `/new` in Telegram, then "hello".

Fix 3 — Force restart:

```
openclaw gateway --force
```

This kills any stuck process and starts fresh. More thorough than a normal restart.

Problem 7

Gateway Dashboard Won't Load in Browser

Symptoms:

- Browser shows 'This site can't be reached' when going to `127.0.0.1:18789`
- Dashboard shows 'device identity required' error

Fix 1 — Make sure the gateway is running:

Check your terminal. If the gateway isn't running, start it with `openc law gateway`. The dashboard only works while the gateway is active.

Fix 2 — Check you're using the right URL:

The default local dashboard URL is: `http://127.0.0.1:18789`

If you started the gateway on a different port (like 18790), use that port number instead.

Fix 3 — 'Device identity required' error:

This happens when the dashboard requires HTTPS but you're accessing it over HTTP locally. Fix it by allowing insecure auth for local access:

```
openclaw config set gateway.controlUi.allowInsecureAuth true
```

Then restart the gateway.

Fix 4 — Check the gateway token:

You might need to paste your gateway token to log in. If you don't know it, you can find it by asking your agent in Telegram, or by running:

```
openclaw doctor --generate-gateway-token
```

Problem 8

Skill Installation Failed or Skill Not Working

Symptoms:

- Skill installs but doesn't work when you try to use it
- Agent says skill is not found or not installed
- VirusTotal flags the skill as suspicious

Fix 1 — VirusTotal flagged it:

Go to clawhub.ai and check the Security Scan section on the skill's page. If both VirusTotal and the OpenClaw scan show Benign, it's safe. Tell your agent to install with `--force`.

Fix 2 — Skill installed but not working:

Some skills need extra setup (like Google OAuth for the GOG skill). Ask your agent: Is the [skill name] skill fully set up? What else needs to be configured?

Fix 3 — Reinstall the skill:

Ask your agent: Uninstall the [skill name] skill and then reinstall it from ClawHub.

Problem 9

Google Workspace (GOG) OAuth Not Connecting

Symptoms:

- OAuth keeps sending you new URLs in a loop
- Authorization completes but the agent doesn't recognise it
- Agent says state is lost or auth code expired

What happened: On local installations, OAuth should work more smoothly than on a VPS because your browser is on the same machine. But sometimes the agent loses state between steps.

Fix 1 — Make sure the gateway is running when you authorize:

The OAuth flow requires the gateway to be active. Don't close or restart the gateway between getting the authorization URL and completing the process.

Fix 2 — Complete it quickly:

The auth code only lasts a few minutes. When you get the URL, open it immediately, authorize, and paste the redirect URL back into Telegram right away.

Fix 3 — If the redirect fails:

When you get the 'This site can't be reached' page after authorizing, copy the entire URL from the address bar and paste it into Telegram. Make sure you copy the whole thing including all the parameters after the `?`.

Fix 4 — Start fresh:

If nothing works, ask the agent for a completely fresh OAuth URL and do the process again from scratch.

Nuclear Option — Reinstall or Restore

If nothing above works, you have two options:

Option 1 — Restore from your backup folder:

If you followed the course advice and copied your `.openclaw` folder before making big changes, you can restore it now. Delete the current `.openclaw` folder and replace it with your backup copy.

Mac / Linux: The folder is at `~/openclaw`

Windows: The folder is at `%USERPROFILE%\openclaw`

To find it: on Mac, open Terminal and type `open ~/openclaw`. On Windows, open a terminal and type `explorer %USERPROFILE%\openclaw`.

Option 2 — Fresh install:

As a last resort, you can do a clean reinstall of OpenClaw:

```
openclaw update
```

If that doesn't help, do a full reinstall:

```
npm install -g openclaw@latest
```

```
openclaw doctor --fix
```

```
openclaw gateway
```

Warning: If you delete your `.openclaw` folder, you will lose all your agent's memory, skills, configuration, and conversation history. Only do this if you have a backup or if you're willing to set everything up again from scratch.

How To Prevent Problems

- **Back up your `.openclaw` folder before big changes** — copy the entire folder to your desktop or an external drive before updating OpenClaw, changing model routing, or installing new skills. On Mac, type `open ~/openclaw` in Terminal to find it. On Windows, type `explorer %USERPROFILE%\openclaw`.
- **Use a strong model for config changes** — cheaper models like Haiku are more likely to guess config values incorrectly and crash OpenClaw. Use Sonnet or better when your agent needs to change any settings.
- **Check what your agent is changing** — if the agent says it's going to update a config value, read what it's proposing. If the value looks unfamiliar, tell the agent to check the OpenClaw docs first.
- **Check credits regularly** — the most common reason for a silent agent is empty credits. Check your API dashboard every few days.
- **Use /new when things feel stuck** — starting a fresh session solves a surprising number of problems. Make it your first thing to try.

- **Keep OpenClaw updated** — run `openc law update` regularly. Newer versions fix bugs and improve config validation.
- **Don't close the terminal window** — the gateway only runs while the terminal is open. If you close it, the agent goes offline. If you need the gateway to run permanently, look into `openc law gateway install` which sets it up as a system service.
- **Keep your computer awake** — when your computer sleeps, the gateway stops. If you need your agent available 24/7, consider running on a VPS instead.

Tip: Tell your agent: "Before you make any config changes, show me exactly what you're going to change and wait for my approval." This gives you a chance to check the values before they're applied.